

A Cry for Recognition: The Unheard Voices of Abor Isiala and Ihenyi (Eha-Amufu)

Communities, Isi-Uzo Local Government Area, Enugu State

It began with a distress call, one that has become all too familiar in the beleaguered communities of Abor Isiala and Ihenyi, Isi-Uzo Local Government Area, Enugu State. A young man, whom we shall call *John*, reached out to South Saharan Social Development Organisation (SSDO) with desperation in his voice. His community was under attack. Armed herdsmen had descended upon Eha-Amufu, sending families fleeing for their lives. Homes were set ablaze, farmlands were razed, and an eerie silence followed the chaos; one filled not just with fear, but with the deafening absence of acknowledgment from those in power.

SSDO, in partnership with ActionAid Nigeria, wasted no time. Alongside the Justice Development and Peace Commission (JDPC), we convened a press conference on March 19, 2025, to shed light on the crisis ravaging Abor Isiala and Ihenyi communities. We spoke of lives lost, of over 7,000 displaced individuals, of women and children bearing the brunt of a conflict they did not create. We demanded action.

However, when we stepped into the community to conduct a needs assessment, which is a crucial step in bringing relief, we were met with something unexpected: ***rejection***.

The people, weary and embittered, refused to participate. They did not see us as an ally but as an extension of the government - a government that had denied their suffering, dismissed their pain, and abandoned them in their time of need. The women, voiced their anger the loudest. "We do not need relief from a government that claims we are not suffering," they said. Those who dared engage with us were branded as saboteurs. The wounds of displacement ran deep, but the greater wound was the one inflicted by silence; by the erasure of their reality.

When Silence is More Painful Than Loss

History has shown us that acknowledgment is the first step toward healing. We saw it in post-apartheid South Africa, where the *Truth and Reconciliation Commission* became the bridge between pain and peace. We saw it in Rwanda, where recognition of the genocide allowed a broken nation to rebuild. But in Isi-Uzo Local Government Area, there is no acknowledgment. No recognition. No justice. Only silence.

The facts on the ground are clear:

- Over **300 people directly affected** in Abor Isiala, with another 100 in Ihenyi.
- Over **20 lives lost**.
- **1,064 children out of school**, with only about 450 managing to return.
- Women subjected to **brutal assaults, including rape**.
- The destruction of farmlands, pushing entire communities into hunger and economic ruin.

Yet, despite these harrowing realities, state authorities have either downplayed or outright denied the crisis. “No community in Eha-Amufu or any part of Enugu State has been invaded, placed under siege, or had its residents displaced, says the Police Spokesperson, SP Daniel Ndukwe (<https://dailytrust.com/no-community-is-under-siege-in-enugu-police/>).

To this, we ask: *How does one control death? How does one deny the cries of starving children and violated women?*

A Call to Action

We at SSDO refuse to stand by while an entire community is harassed and erased from public consciousness. We demand:

1. **Recognition and accountability:** The government must acknowledge this crisis, stop the denial, and take responsibility.
2. **A permanent security presence:** No more intermittent deployments. These communities need lasting protection.
3. **Humanitarian aid:** Food, shelter, medical supplies - these are not luxuries; they are lifelines.
4. **Justice for the victims:** The perpetrators must be held accountable. Silence only fuels impunity.
5. **Access to education:** The children of Eha-Amufu deserve a future beyond trauma and displacement.

To the government, we say: *You cannot ignore the people whose votes you seek during elections.* To the people of Nigeria, we say: *Let your voices rise with theirs, because today, it is Eha-Amufu, but tomorrow, it could be any one of us.*

We will not stop amplifying their cries until justice is served.